

built over the years. “Neither one farmer nor one region grows everything. For example, ITC buys tobacco in Guntur and wheat from elsewhere. That means the backend synergies at the farmer’s level are not obvious, though the capabilities are fungible in a sense,” he says. The approach will be to take the Amul brand name and trust to the farmers. “It will be over a decade, and they will finally get it right, but one should not expect an overnight success.”

P FOR PROTEIN

Milk is a good source of protein, but there is also a need for whey (the liquid that remains after milk has been curdled), which is a quality protein. Many years ago, when Mehta was running Amul Dairy (the Kaira District Co-operative Milk Producers’ Union), he spent time understanding whey but realised a lot of money was needed to reprocess it. But a solution was needed.

Typically, the need for protein is a gm for each kilo you weigh or 60 gm daily for someone who stands at 60 kg. “With milk, *dal* and buttermilk, you will get a maximum of 30 gm,” says Mehta. Since importing protein is arduous, Amul launched a high-protein *lassi* and buttermilk by dissolving whey powder. “The taste of the buttermilk is different but about conscious consumption. Our *lassi* is sugar-free.”

K.S. Narayanan, an independent food advisor, says Amul’s protein move “is an excellent initiative considering the way the markets are evolving”. Indians, he says, have a diet deficient in protein. “With rising per capita income, the quality of food consumption has undergone a big change and additional protein in mass-consuming products like *dahi* (curd) or buttermilk is a good way for consumers to make it a part of their diet.”

Mehta shows the artwork for a protein shake *lassi*. “We can launch a protein ice cream or high-protein milk, cereals, snacks, yoghurt or chocolates. Even a protein chocos is possible, where it is an FMCG product, but I come with the ingredients,” he says.

One challenge that Amul has faced is the availability of its products at retail outlets. Buying it in Anand is one thing, but that’s not the case in other centres. This is where e-commerce has been a big help, and Amul, with its Shop Amul online store, offers a substantial part of the range. “I do this with the existing warehouse system and sell at MRP.”

Nitin Karkare, Vice Chairman of FCB Ulka Advertising, which has handled a substantial part of the Amul account for over three decades, says they have got it right on the basics like superior product, better packaging, value for money, consistency in communi-

THE AMUL SPREAD

► Amul has benefitted by offering hygienic packaged products

► In foods, the opportunity is similar and by choosing specific segments like organic, the growth story can really take off



POTENTIAL TO DISRUPT

